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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

GST 107: Nigerian Peoples and Culture - Diversity, History and Nation-Building

The context every Nigerian graduate should be able to explain without slogans

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack organises Nigeria's pre-colonial societies, cultural institutions, colonial experience and post-independence challenges into clear themes you can actually remember. It replaces vague 'unity in diversity' answers with specific examples, dates and arguments.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe the political and social organisation of at least three pre-colonial Nigerian societies.
- Explain how colonialism reshaped Nigerian economies, identities and boundaries.
- Distinguish cultural relativism from ethnocentrism with Nigerian examples.
- Discuss national integration using evidence rather than slogans.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Peoples, cultures and the danger of stereotypes

Nigeria has more than 250 ethnic groups and over 500 languages. The three largest - Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba and Igbo - are often used as shorthand, but that shorthand hides enormous internal diversity.

Culture includes language, religion, food, dress, marriage, music, craft, political organisation and shared values. It is learned and changes over time; it is not biological.

Ethnocentrism judges another culture by the standards of one's own. Cultural relativism tries to understand a practice within its own context - without pretending that every practice is beyond criticism.

- Hausa city-states and the Sokoto Caliphate: centralised emirate administration, Islamic scholarship and trans-Saharan trade.
- Yoruba kingdoms: Ife and Oyo, divine kingship, the Oyo cavalry and a rich oral and artistic tradition.
- Igbo societies: largely acephalous village republics, age grades, title societies such as Ozo, and the Nri ritual complex.

- Minority and riverine peoples: the Tiv, Ijaw, Efik, Ibibio, Nupe, Kanuri and many others with distinct political systems.

Pre-colonial trade, craft and knowledge

Long before colonial boundaries, the area that became Nigeria had sophisticated economies and knowledge systems.

- Trans-Saharan trade linked Kano and Katsina to North Africa through leather, salt, kola and horses.
- The trans-Atlantic slave trade devastated communities and created wealth for intermediaries; its consequences outlasted abolition.
- Benin bronzes, Ife terracotta heads, Nok figures and Igbo-Ukwu bronzes show advanced metallurgy and artistry.
- Palm oil production, fishing, weaving, blacksmithing and salt making supported regional trade.
- Indigenous medicine, astronomy and agriculture were systems of knowledge, not mere superstition.

Colonialism and its long shadow

Colonial rule lasted roughly six decades but reorganised almost everything: boundaries, administration, economy, education and identity.

The 1884-85 Berlin Conference set the framework for European partition. The Royal Niger Company and later the British colonial administration merged protectorates in 1914 into a single entity.

Colonial economies were built around extraction - palm produce, cocoa, groundnuts, tin and later oil - with infrastructure designed to move goods to ports rather than connect Nigerian communities.

Indirect rule deepened some ethnic identities and created new administrative divisions. Mission schools produced a new elite that later led nationalist movements.

> **Exam precision**
> Do not write that 'the British united Nigeria'. They amalgamated territories for administrative convenience. The consequences - uneven development and contested citizenship - are still with us.

Nationalism, independence and nation-building

Nationalist movements used newspapers, unions, market associations and political parties to demand self-government.

- Early nationalism: Herbert Macaulay and the NNDP; the Aba Women's War of 1929 against colonial taxation.
- Mass nationalism: Nnamdi Azikiwe, Obafemi Awolowo, Ahmadu Bello and the parties they led.
- Independence in 1960; a republic in 1963; civil war from 1967 to 1970.
- Military rule alternated with short democratic periods until civilian rule returned in 1999.
- Federal character, state creation and revenue allocation are responses to the challenge of governing diversity.

Nation-building is not the same as unity

Unity is a condition; nation-building is the work of creating institutions and loyalties that make diversity governable. Cite specific institutions such as the NYSC, federal character and national language policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is cultural relativism?

Answer: The view that a culture should be understood in terms of its own values and context rather than judged by the standards of another culture.

2. Name two features of pre-colonial Igbo political organisation.

Answer: Village assemblies and age-grade associations; title societies such as Ozo; and decentralised governance without a single paramount ruler in many communities.

3. Why was the 1914 amalgamation significant?

Answer: It joined the Northern and Southern Protectorates into one administrative unit, shaping the boundaries and governance structure of modern Nigeria.

4. Distinguish ethnocentrism from racism.

Answer: Ethnocentrism judges other cultures by one's own cultural standards. Racism asserts that racial groups have inherent superior or inferior qualities and often justifies discrimination.

5. Give one economic effect of colonial rule in Nigeria.

Answer: The economy was reorganised around export crops and mineral extraction for European markets, with infrastructure built mainly to move goods to ports.

6. What is federal character, and why is it controversial?

Answer: A constitutional principle requiring fair representation of Nigeria's diverse groups in public institutions. Critics argue it can undermine merit; supporters argue it protects inclusion in a deeply unequal federation.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Draw a map of Nigeria's six geopolitical zones and label three ethnic groups in each.
- [ ] Write one paragraph each on pre-colonial Hausa, Yoruba and Igbo political systems.
- [ ] Create a timeline from 1884 to 1999 with ten key events.
- [ ] Explain three ways colonialism changed Nigerian education and economy.
- [ ] Learn five cultural practices from groups outside your own without caricature.
- [ ] Write a balanced answer on whether Nigeria is a nation or merely a state.
- [ ] Discuss one current national issue using historical context rather than blame.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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